

Mingjian Li

University of Illinois Chicago, School of Public Health
1603 West Taylor Street, Chicago, IL 60607

Email: mli223@uic.edu
Phone: +1 (319) 594-2629

Education

University of Illinois Chicago , Chicago, IL Ph.D., Health Policy and Administration, Field (Health Economics)	Expected 2026
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University of Wisconsin-Madison , Madison, WI Master of Economics	2020
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University of Iowa , Iowa City, IA B.B.A, Finance; B.S., Mathematics	2018
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Fields of Interest

Health Economics, Public Policy, Applied Econometrics, Medicaid

References

Professor Lisa M. Powell Health Policy and Administration University of Illinois Chicago powelll@uic.edu +1 (312) 413-3544	Professor Jennifer H. Kwok Health Policy and Administration University of Illinois Chicago jenkwok@uic.edu +1 (201) 315-2586	Professor Ben Ost Economics University of Illinois Chicago bost@uic.edu +1 (312) 996-3913
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Working Papers

"Does Medicaid Expansion Lead to Income Adjustment? Evidence from the Survey of Income Program Participation" (JMP)

Abstract: Using monthly Survey of Income Program Participation (SIPP) data and a regression discontinuity (RD) design at the 138 percent of the Federal Poverty Line (FPL) threshold, this paper shows that childless adults in Medicaid expansion states lowered their lowest-month earnings by about 39 FPL percentage points (\$700 in 2025 dollars for a two-person household) to qualify for Medicaid. The response is largest when the individual mandate penalty was highest (2015–2016) and attenuates after the penalty was set to zero in 2019. Evidence from zero-earnings months and hours worked indicates adjustments along both extensive and intensive margins. These findings validate lowest-month earnings as the practical eligibility measure and provide novel evidence of substantial labor-supply responses to the Affordable Care Act's Medicaid notch.

"How Is MAGI-Based Medicaid Eligibility Determined?"

Abstract: Despite the apparent complexity of MAGI rules, this paper shows, by directly referencing federal regulations (42 CFR §435) and Centers for Medicare and Medicaid Services documentation, that Medicaid eligibility in practice is determined by the lowest monthly earnings within a year, rather than annual income measures. Using Survey of Income and Program Participation monthly panel data, this paper finds a sharp and visually clear discontinuity in Medicaid enrollment at 138 percent of the federal poverty line (FPL) when eligibility is measured using lowest monthly earnings

within a calendar year. In contrast, alternative eligibility methods, including lowest monthly income defined as earnings plus other income, median monthly earnings, and annual earnings, fail to generate any comparable enrollment gap. Simulation exercises show that annual income measures mechanically attenuate eligibility discontinuities because they average over months with substantial within-year earnings variation. This helps explain why studies relying on cross-sectional data such as the Current Population Survey often fail to detect clear eligibility-driven effects.

Work in Progress

”Do People Reduce Their Income for CHIP Eligibility? Evidence from Tax Returns”

”Does Tracking Increase Grades Disparities?”

Conference Presentations

2026	Midwest Economics Association (scheduled)
2026	Population Association of America (scheduled)
2025	American Society of Health Economists: ASHEcon (presenter)
2025	Illinois Economics Association (presenter and discussant)

Teaching Experience

Independent Instructor

Fall 2023	HPA 440. Healthcare Data Analytics
Fall 2022	HPA 521. Empirical Methods for Health Research I

Teaching Assistant

Fall 2024, 2025	HPA 463. Managerial Health Economics
Fall 2024, 2025	HPA 460. Introduction to the Economics of Health and Healthcare
Spring 2024, 2025	HPA 451. Health Care Finance I
Spring 2024, 2025	HPA 567. Public Health Policy Analysis

Research Experience

2023-2024	Research Assistant for Dr. Lisa M. Powell
2020-2022	Research Assistant for Dr. Betsy Cliff

Languages and Skills

Languages: Mandarin (native), English (fluent), Spanish (elementary)

Skills: Stata, Python, SAS, L^AT_EX